

THE MUSEUM OF FINE ARTS

Thursday, 26 March 2026, 12:45 - 2:15 PM EST.

Museum of Fine Arts

THE RENAISSANCE OF NORTHERN EUROPE AND ITALY progressed towards realism in separate ways. Michelangelo made this distinction in an ungenerous way:

In Flanders they paint with a view to external exactness or such things as may cheer you and of which you cannot speak ill, as for example saints and prophets. They paint stuffs and masonry, the green grass of the fields, the shadow of trees, and rivers and bridges, which they call landscapes, with many figures on this side and many figures on that. And all this, though it pleases some persons, is done without reason or art, without symmetry or proportion, without skilful choice or boldness and, finally, without substance or vigour.

Paulus Potter (1625-1654) *Young Bull* is a direct answer to Michelangelo's criticism. Michelangelo mocked attention to masonry, grass, trees, rivers, and merely visible things. Yet Potter takes the natural world of visible particulars and turns it into a work of high ambition. The bull is not a minor subject, but monumental in scale. The flies, the hide, the damp nose, the distant church, and the receding meadow are not decorative. They are factual reality. The painting succeeds in sustained attention to visible reality. Potter suggests that realism can itself be high artistic achievements.



Figure 166: Paulus Potter, *Young Bull*, 1647, oil on canvas, 235.5 × 339 cm (roughly 7 ft 9 in × 11 ft 1 in). [Mauritshuis, The Hague](#). Potter grants a humble animal the scale and authority that Michelangelo reserved for heroic subjects. Yet the painting's apparent photographic realism is itself a carefully staged illusion: the bull is a composite assembled from multiple studies rather than a portrait of one beast. Its realism is therefore not mere "external exactness," but a deliberate artistic construction.

THE NETHERLANDISH MAP offered another metaphor for faithful representation in Northern art. The more exact a map's description of the visible world, the more useful it could be. In the seventeenth-century Dutch Republic, hanging maps served not only as cartographic tools but also as wall decorations. They celebrated the republic's nautical reach and commercial wealth. This wealth supported Dutch achievement in art and science.

VERMEER returned repeatedly to maps and mapmaking in his paintings. The map of Holland and West Friesland in *Officer and Laughing Girl* was based on a map made by Willem Blaeu in 1621. The only solitary men in Vermeer's paintings – *The Astronomer* and *The Geographer* – are both figures associated with scientific and cartographic inquiry. Vermeer painted his largest and most elaborate map in *The Art of Painting* (Fig. 170). This painting about painting, one of his finest late works, may also include the artist himself. Vermeer renders this map – the Seventeen Provinces of the Netherlands with twenty views of Dutch cities, after Claes Janszoon Visscher's 1636 design – with greater care than contemporary painters such as Ochtervelt, who used similar maps as studio props (Fig. 167). By placing his signature on the map itself, Vermeer aligns the painter with the cartographer and suggests that painting, too, is an art of description.



Figure 167: Jacob Ochtervelt, *The Music Lesson*, 1671. [Art Institute of Chicago](#). Unlike Vermeer, Ochtervelt uses the wall map primarily as a prop rather than an object that sustains visual attention.



Figure 168: Vermeer's signature in *The Art of Painting*, placed on the map itself. By signing the cartographic image, Vermeer aligns himself as both painter and mapmaker.

Figure 169: Johannes Vermeer, *Officer and Laughing Girl*, ca. 1657. [The Frick Collection, New York](#). The prominently displayed wall map announces Vermeer's recurring interest in cartography as both a sign of Dutch domestic culture and a metaphor for faithful description.



Figure 170: Johannes Vermeer, *The Art of Painting*, ca. 1666–68. [Kunsthistorisches Museum, Vienna](#). Vermeer renders the great wall map with unusual care and even places his signature on it, aligning the authority of the painter with that of the cartographer.

Updated: April 6, 2026

The map appears as more than a decorative object or an emblem of prosperity. It also serves as a figure for representation itself: the world as visual image. From there, it is only a short step to paintings that are directly about painting. Such images reveal painting as a constructed mode of knowledge, poised between observation and invention. Vermeer joined these two ideas in *The Art of Painting*, where the artist reflects on representation while also inserting himself into the work.

Rogier van der Weyden (1400–1464), a contemporary of van Eyck, pursued a similar self-reflexive ambition in *Saint Luke Drawing the Virgin*. In this familiar Renaissance motif, Saint Luke, patron saint of painters, sketches the Virgin Mary and the infant Jesus. To paint is to create an illusion of reality. This painting makes this point explicitly. The scene is not historical record but a fiction about artistic making. Saint Luke does not simply copy what is before him; he represents the imagination of the painter.



Figure 171: Rogier van der Weyden, *Saint Luke Drawing the Virgin*, about 1435–40. [Museum of Fine Arts, Boston](#). The patron saint of painters is shown drawing the Virgin and Child, turning the sacred scene into a meditation on artistic making. Saint Luke has often been interpreted as a self-portrait of van der Weyden.

THE REPRESENTATION OF REPRESENTATION is explored in Diego Velázquez's *Las Meninas* (1656). Velázquez (1599–1660) served as court painter to Philip IV during the Spanish Golden Age. An inventory made after his death reveals that he owned books on geometry, perspective, and painting, including works by Dürer, Alberti, Euclid, and Leonardo, as well as a large collection of mirrors. He was not only a painter of extraordinary skill, but also a serious student of optics and perspective.

Painted on a monumental canvas nearly ten feet high and more than ten feet wide, *Las Meninas* depicts a room in the Royal Alcázar of Madrid. At its center stands the five-year-old Infanta Margarita Teresa. Velázquez includes himself, stepping back from a large canvas and looking outward into the viewer's space. The painter, the Infanta, and several attendants all direct their attention beyond the picture. In this way, Velázquez presents himself not as a servant of the court, but as a presence within it.

Velázquez's "representation of representation" unfolds in layers. We seem to occupy the place of the unseen figures observed by the people in the room. At the back hangs a mirror, in which appear King Philip IV and Queen Mariana, the parents of the Infanta. Is the viewer meant to stand where the royal couple stands?

Velázquez plays with possibilities through perspective. The architecture of the room draws toward a vanishing point at the open doorway in the rear, where a court official pauses on the stairs. Because the vanishing point marks the orthogonal axis of the depicted space, the viewer's position does not align simply with the reflected image in the mirror. The reflection seems displaced from our own viewpoint.

Scale introduces another complication. The reflected king and queen appear roughly comparable in size to the figure in the distant doorway. Yet if they were actually standing in the viewer's place, their mirror image would require a much greater path of reflected light than the image of the doorway figure. For that reason, the mirror may not reflect the king and queen directly at all, but rather an enlarged painted image of them on the canvas before Velázquez. The painting remains deliberately ambiguous. *Las Meninas* thus becomes a meditation on the instability of visual representation itself: on what it means to see, to paint, and to represent.

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Figure 172: Before *Las Meninas* in 1656, Velázquez painted the Infanta as a teenager in 1653, one of many copies sent to suitors. She eventually married Louis XIV of France. [Link to MFA](#)

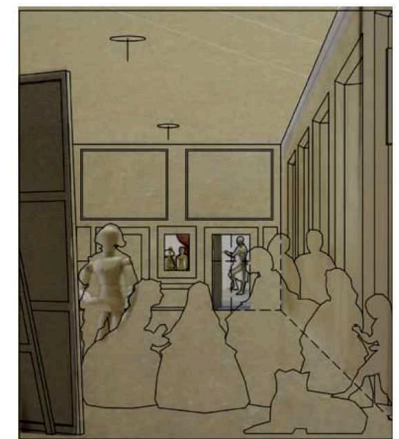
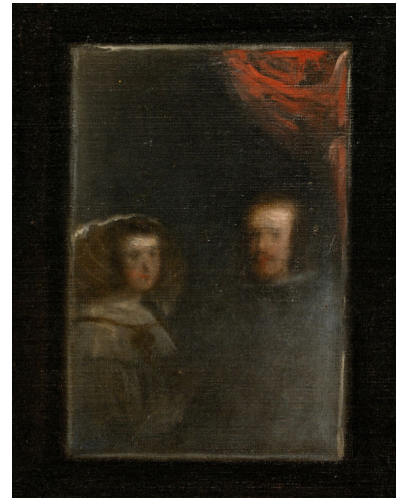


Figure 173: Perspectival analysis from Hernandez2018



Figure 174: Diego Velázquez, *Las Meninas*, 1656. [Museo del Prado, Madrid](#). Velázquez stages the Infanta Margarita Teresa and her entourage in a room of the Royal Alcázar, while inserting himself at the left before a large canvas. A mirror at the back reflects the king and queen, but the geometry of the room leaves ambiguous whether they stand in the viewer's space or appear only as an image within the painting. The work thus collapses the boundaries between portrait, self-portrait, and reflection, making the act of representation itself its central subject.

VELÁZQUEZ heightens the visual fascination of *Las Meninas* by exploiting the paradox at the heart of all painting: the representation of three-dimensional space on a two-dimensional surface. Any flat image of volumetric space must, in some sense, be an illusion. But *Las Meninas* goes further. It turns the viewer into a participant in the scene it stages. Velázquez encourages us to search for its plot. Is the Infanta visiting the painter at work? Has she just responded to the entrance of her parents? Are we standing in the place of the king and queen, or are we something else entirely?

VELÁZQUEZ HAD ALREADY EXPLORED VISUAL PARADOX and pictorial storytelling in an earlier work, *Don Baltasar Carlos and an Attendant* (1632). Here the young heir to the throne appears at about two years old, accompanied by a dwarf or court attendant who holds a rattle and an apple – playthings that echo the scepter and orb the prince will one day bear as king. But the painting unsettles the scene it presents. Is the attendant really standing beside the prince, or before a painted image of him? Velázquez deliberately leaves the matter unresolved, inviting the viewer to construct the story for themselves.



Figure 175: Diego Velázquez, *Don Baltasar Carlos and an Attendant*, 1632. [Museum of Fine Arts, Boston](#). Baltasar Carlos, the two-year-old heir to the Spanish throne, appears in ceremonial dress beside a dwarf who holds a rattle and an apple – playful counterparts to the scepter and orb he will one day bear as king. Velázquez subtly unsettles the scene by making the attendant's relation to the prince spatially ambiguous, turning a dynastic portrait into an exercise in pictorial play.

Velázquez turns painting into a meditation on the instability of representation, between pictorial fiction and visual fact. In Dutch illusionism, the problem was not how painting represents space, but how a painted surface might momentarily hide its own flatness and present itself as reality. Illusion itself is the subject of representation.

Samuel van Hoogstraten (1627-1678) was a student of Rembrandt and theorist. He wrote:

The Art of Painting is a science for representing all the ideas or notions which the whole of visible nature is able to produce and for deceiving the eye with drawing and color... I say that a painter whose work it is to fool the sense of sight also must have so much understanding of the nature of things that he thoroughly understands the means by which the eyes are deceived.

IN DYRHAM PARK, GLOUCESTERSHIRE, Hoogstraten painted a remarkable illusion on the wall of a country house. Approaching the picture, the viewer seems to look down a corridor opening onto a sequence of rooms beyond. Yet the fiction collapses at the very moment of arrival: the eye expects passage, but the body meets a wall.

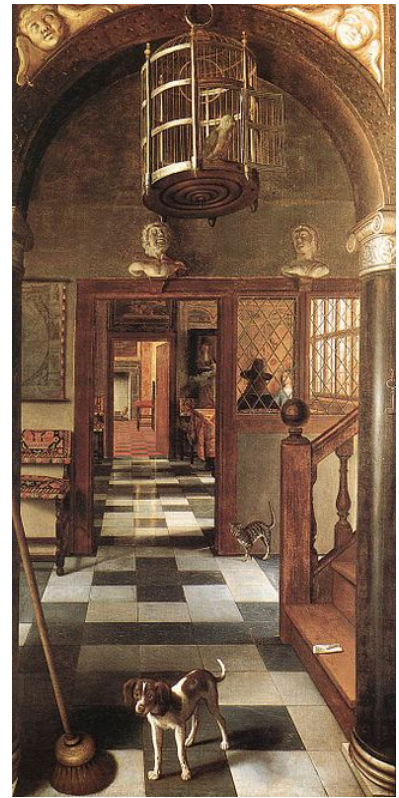
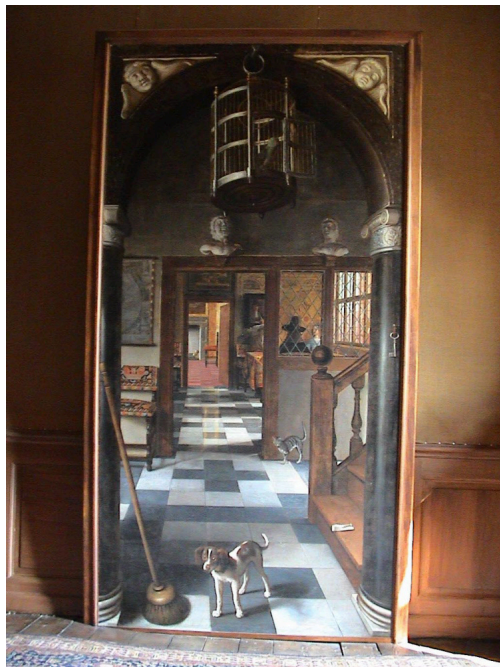


Figure 176: Samuel van Hoogstraten, *View of a Corridor*, 1662, installed in a doorway at Dyrham Park, Gloucestershire, as the artist intended. Seen from the proper vantage, the painting creates the illusion of a corridor opening onto a sequence of rooms beyond, turning the threshold itself into an experiment in pictorial deception.

ANOTHER POPULAR FORM OF ILLUSIONISM in Netherlandish art was *trompe l'œil*, French for 'deceive the eye'. Hendrik de Framantiou (1633-1693) painted a dead partridge (and crawling snail) on a canvas meant to look like the wall on which the painting is hung.

CAREL FABRITIUS (1622-1654) made the best known painting in this tradition, *The Goldfinch*. Fabritius is remembered as Rembrandt's best student, but was killed in 1654 in the Delft gunpowder explosion that destroyed a quarter of the city and his studio. Only a dozen paintings survive.



Figure 177: Carel Fabritius, *The Goldfinch*, 1654, oil on panel, 33.5 × 22.8 cm. [Mauritshuis, The Hague](#). Chained by its foot to a feeding-box against a plaster wall, this small captive bird is painted with clarity and presence. The low viewpoint and wall-like background suggest that the panel may have served as a *trompe l'œil* element.

Figure 178: Hendrik de Framantiou, *Trompe l'Œil with a Dead Partridge*, 1666. [Museum of Fine Arts, Boston](#). A dead partridge hangs limply against an apparently plain wall, accompanied by a small snail. Framantiou turns a still life into a meditation on illusion and mortality.

Trompe l'œil was not only a display of virtuosity. Illusion could also serve a devotional purpose, closing distance between sacred image and beholder.

HANS MEMLING (1430–1494), who trained in the orbit of Rogier van der Weyden, used *trompe l'œil* to create the illusion of Christ offering his blessing through a window in the wall. Christ's fingers rest on the painted frame as though on the sill of a real opening through which he appears before us. Illusion is not deception, but creates presence, bringing the sacred figure into the viewer's space.



Figure 179: Hans Memling, *Christ Blessing*, 1481, oil on panel, 35.1 × 25.1 cm. [Museum of Fine Arts, Boston](#). Christ is shown half-length against a dark ground, raising his right hand in blessing while his left hand supports a crystal orb. His fingers rest on the painted frame as if on the sill of a window, so that the sacred figure seems to cross the boundary between pictorial space and the viewer's own.

PIETER SAENREDAM (1597–1665) turns illusion in a quieter direction. His church interiors do not break through the picture plane, but move vision into an architectural space. He is best known for his paintings of Dutch church interiors. Lines of convergence sweep upwards and downwards, at first glance evoking the mathematically ordered spaces of the Italian Renaissance. But Saenredam did not simply construct these interiors according to abstract laws of perspective. He began from what he saw, as his preparatory sketches show (Fig. 182), and then modified those drawings when making later paintings. Saenredam thus drew with a moving eye: he looked leftward for the sketch on the left and rightward for the sketch on the right. The right sketch would later serve for the painting now in the National Gallery in London (Fig. 181), while the left would serve for the painting now in the Kimbell Art Museum in Houston (Fig. 180).



Figure 181: *The Interior of the Buurkerk at Utrecht* by Pieter Saenredam, 1644. The Buurkerk was constructed between the thirteenth and fifteenth centuries but had been remodeled by the Dutch Golden Age in the unadorned Protestant style that Saenredam paints. Multicolored walls have been whitewashed. Catholic altarpieces have been removed. [Link to National Gallery in London.](#)



Figure 180: *The Interior of the Buurkerk at Utrecht* by Pieter Saenredam, 1644. [Link to Kimbell Art Museum.](#)

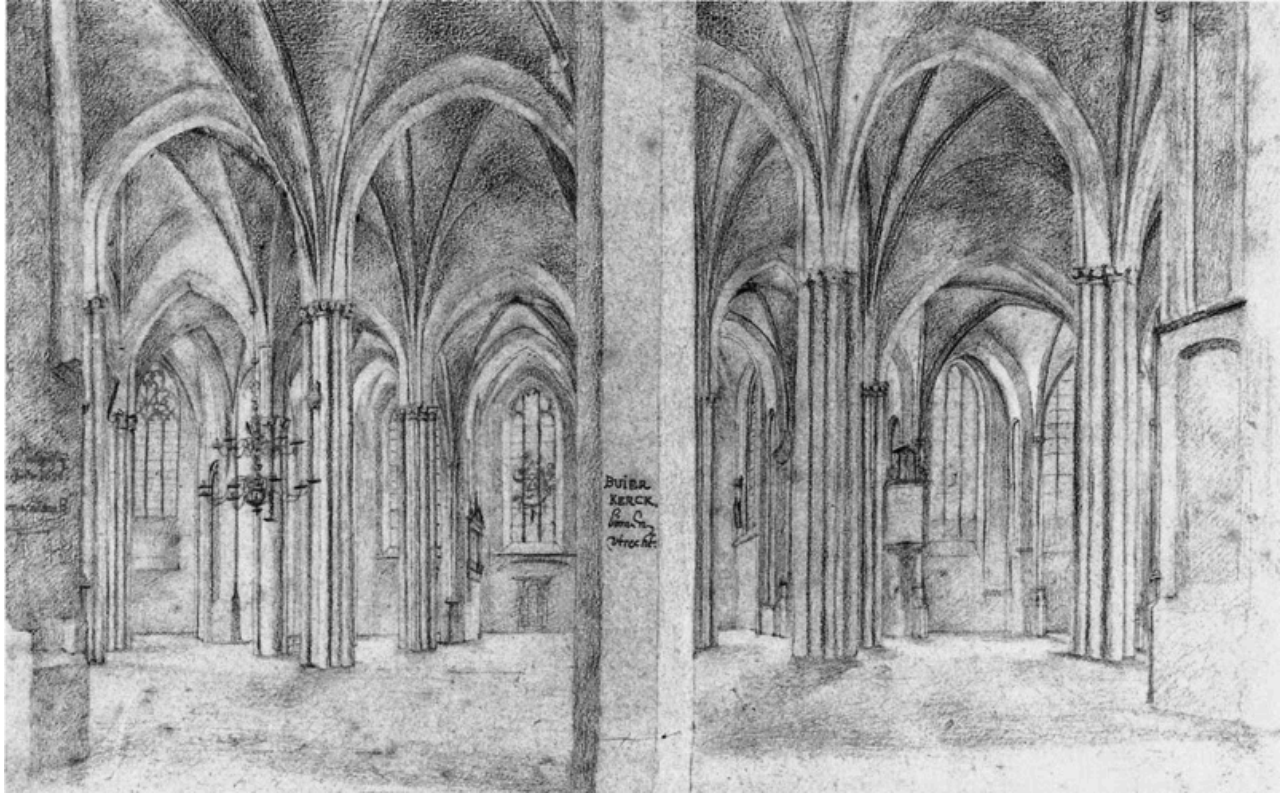


Figure 182: *The Interior of the Buurkerk at Utrecht* by Pieter Saenredam, preparatory drawings in pen and chalk on paper.

SAENREDAM'S PAINTING of Saint Bavo Church in Haarlem, now in the Museum of Fine Arts, Boston, presents not a neutral transcription of what the eye sees, but a modified reality (Fig. 183). Saenredam painted this church more than twenty times. Here he tilts the perspective lines to exaggerate height, making the vaulted space appear more elevated than it would in reality.



Figure 183: *St. Bavo Church* by Pieter Saenredam, 1660. [Link to MFA](#)

ANOTHER WAY TO READ SAENREDAM is as an artist who discovered a quiet, even austere beauty in geometry and line. The most fundamental element of his pale, luminous church interiors is not narrative or ornament, but the line itself. Walls, arches, vaults, and columns are reduced to a measured orchestration of verticals, horizontals, and diagonals.

Two centuries later, another Dutch painter, Piet Mondrian (1872–1944), would carry this logic much further. Mondrian stripped painting down to line and color alone. What remains implicit in Saenredam's church interiors becomes explicit in Mondrian: the search for order, clarity, and beauty through the most elementary means of visual form.

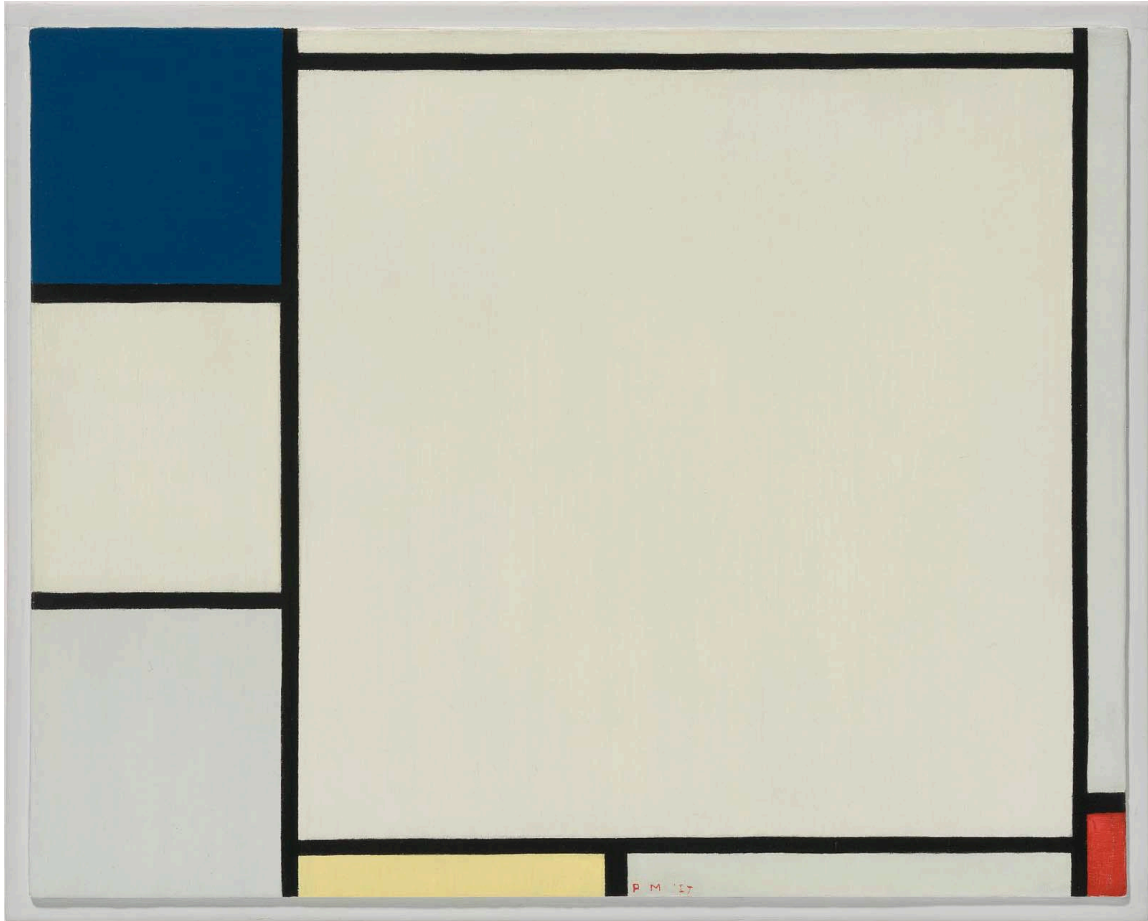


Figure 184: *Composition with Blue, Yellow, and Red* by Piet Mondrian, 1927.
[Link to MFA](#)

MONDRIAN AND SAENREDAM probably knew a story recorded by Pliny the Elder, in his *Natural History*, Book 35, about two great artists of Ancient Greece, Apelles and Protogenes.

A clever incident took place between Protogenes and Apelles. Protogenes lived at Rhodes, and Apelles made the voyage there from a desire to make himself acquainted with Protogenes's works, as that artist was hitherto only known to him by reputation.

He went at once to his studio. The artist was not there but there was a panel of considerable size on the easel prepared for painting, which was in the charge of a single old woman.

In answer to his enquiry, she told him that Protogenes was not at home, and asked who it was she should report as having wished to see him. 'Say it was this person,' said Apelles, and taking up a brush he painted in colour across the panel an extremely fine line;

and when Protogenes returned the old woman showed him what had taken place. The story goes that the artist, after looking closely at the finish of this, said that the new arrival was Apelles, as so perfect a piece of work tallied with nobody else; and he himself, using another colour, drew a still finer line exactly on the top of the first one, and leaving the room told the attendant to show it to the visitor if he returned and add that this was the person he was in search of;

and so it happened; for Apelles came back, and, ashamed to be beaten, cut the lines with another in a third colour, leaving no room for any further display of minute work.

Hereupon Protogenes admitted he was defeated, and flew down to the harbour to look for the visitor; and he decided that the panel should be handed on to posterity as it was, to be admired as a marvel by everybody, but particularly by artists.

MODERN ART in the Western tradition. sounds like it began with the lines of Apelles and Protogenes, long before Saenredam and Mondrian.

THE STILL LIFE

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ITALIAN RENAISSANCE PERSPECTIVE taught painters how to organize the world on the basis of visual geometry. Northern European realism posed a somewhat different problem: how the visible world might be described with enough care to become a source of knowledge. In the North, pictorial accuracy was not merely a technical achievement or deceptive illusionism. It increasingly converged with a broader belief, shared by both artists and scientists, that understanding begins in careful observation.

Francis Bacon (1561–1626) is often credited with turning empiricism an intellectual program. He argued that knowledge must begin in the rigorous observation of nature. Bacon's influence extended widely through seventeenth-century intellectual culture. Constantijn Huygens, who helped shape attitudes toward Netherlandish art and championed artists including Rembrandt and Jan Lievens, was deeply responsive to this empirical ethos, as were Robert Hooke (1635–1703) and Isaac Newton (1643–1727).

Huygens admired visual representation grounded in close attention. In science, this commitment to accurate depiction found a clear expression in Robert Hooke's *Micrographia* (1665), a work that joined minute observation and illustration.

Hooke used the microscope to reveal the intricate structures of insects and other small forms of life. *Micrographia* shows that images could describe nature with a precision and immediacy that language alone could not match.

Micrographia uses both words and images to describe nature. Comparing Hooke's verbal description with his drawings reveals the limits of language when confronted with a newly visible world.

The Eye of a Fly in one kind of light appears almost like a lattice, drill'd through with abundance of small holes... in the Sunshine they look like a surface cover'd with golden Nails; in another posture, like a surface cover'd with pyramids; in another with Cones; and in other postures of quite other shapes.

But this descriptive power was not confined to science. Artists cultivated observation that was grounded in patience, exactitude, and visible detail. In the Netherlands, one of the clearest examples is Jacques de Gheyn II, whose studies of insects, flowers, shells, and small animals transform close observation into art.

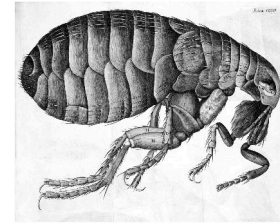


Figure 185: Robert Hooke, *Flea*, engraving from *Micrographia* (London, 1665). Hooke's image turns microscopic observation into a form of visual knowledge, making the tiny body of the insect available to sustained scrutiny.

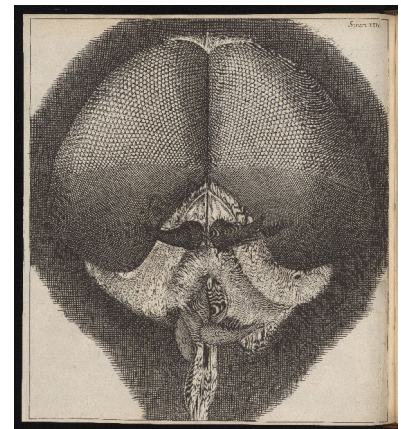


Figure 186: Robert Hooke, *Eye and head of a grey drone fly*, engraving from *Micrographia* (London, 1665). The image gives precise visual form to structures that Hooke's prose can only approximate. [Wellcome Collection](#).

DE GHEYN'S DRAWINGS are at the threshold between scientific description and artistic invention. In *Four Studies of a Diseased Mouse*, he examines the animal from multiple angles, lingering over its swollen eyes, roughened fur, and collapsed posture with almost anatomical attention. The drawing records the small and damaged creature with the same seriousness that Hooke brought to the flea and the fly's eye. The result is beautiful and unsettling: a work of art shaped by careful scrutiny.



Figure 187: Jacques de Gheyn II, *Four Studies of a Diseased Mouse*, ca. 1600–1610. De Gheyn studies the animal from several angles with nearly scientific patience, turning close observation into both description and art. [Rijksmuseum](#).

THE DUTCH STILL LIFE also reveals a taste for microscopic dissection and displaying every facet of an object. The Dutch Republic is credited with the emergence of the still life as a form of high art. Specialists in the still life, like Pieter Claesz (1597-1661) and Willem Kalf (1619-1693), would paint tableau of cheese, fish, fruit, and serving vessels, revealing inside, outside, and underside. Foods are sliced open. Lemon rinds are unwound. Objects are dissected and exposed. The eye is drawn to every optical detail that is faithfully captured with paint and brush.



Figure 188: *Still Life* by Pieter Claesz, 1627. Still life did not develop into its own distinct style until the 17th century. Pieter Claesz in Haarlem specialized in these still lifes, devising different arrangements to display all dimensions of common objects. [Link to Timken Museum](#).



Figure 189: *Still Life with Tazza* by Pieter Claesz, 1636. Various objects strewn on a table, including sliced lemon. The tazza is the lavishly decorated silver drinking vessel. [Link to Mauritshuis](#)

ABRAHAM VAN BEYEREN (1620-1690) was a Dutch Baroque painter of still lifes. He often includes lemons, maximizing their view with sliced and unwound peel (Fig. 190). The lemon is deliberately exposed for the curious eye, not as it might sit in a fruit bowl. Here, the artist also includes himself reflected in the convex mirror of the silver jug.

HIGH-END ARTISTS often included expensive and rare collectibles in still life, a way of making paintings more attractive to wealthy buyers (Fig. 189). In the Netherlands, paintings had to compete in a fierce market. Between 1640 and 1660, Dutch artists made *1.3 million paintings*. Artists mastered new ways to make themselves competitive.



Figure 190: *Ostentatious still life with self-portrait of the artist in the silver jug* by Abraham van Beyeren, ca. 1655 [Link to Mauritshuis](#).

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